

The difference in use of abbreviations between academically educated writers and practically educated writers.

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Abstract

This paper aims to look into the difference of use of abbreviations between writers who have had an education and those who did not have one. by using a program to tokenize the novels chosen from the project Gutenberg dataset. We can get an average of the amount of abbreviations used. Based on this average we can draw a conclusion

1 Introduction

Working in a big company usually means that you have a lot of differently educated people working there. The higher ups are mostly academically educated people whilst most warehouse employees are practically educated. The language that these groups use can differ drastically. This can lead to miscommunication and a distortion of the workflow. But does the same apply to writers? Does your educational background change the way you would write a book? Since language is really big and complex we will focus only on the use of abbreviations between the writers. From this we can conclude our Research Question:

What is the difference in use of abbreviations between writers with an academic background and writers without one?

based on the related work we can theorize the following hypothesis:

The academically educated writers will use more abbreviations than the writers who are not academically educated.

To answer this question and confirm or deny our hypothesis we will conduct an experiment and look at available literature.

2 Related Work

There is a lot of different research done looking into writing and language mostly in the differences between ages and or gender. For example S Jones researched the difference between boys and girls Jones and Myhill (2007). There is also a lot of research done in the use of abbreviations or the so called SMS language. This language is the main source of abbreviations in our daily lives as words like before are turned into be4. These abbreviations are becoming more common in academic papers Aguta-Ofoha (2021).

SMS language is quite common for newer students starting and this language has an impact on the students writing there essays and papers Braimoh (2024). The amount that a student uses SMS language is different for each student however most students know this SMS language and are able to communicate through it. There are a lot of case studies towards this subject however there is a gap in the research containing education level. There are almost no studies looking into the difference in writing between writers who have had a education and those who did not. That is why we chose this subject.

3 Data

The data we collect from 2 writers with known educational backgrounds. To minimize the effects of other independent variables both authors need to write in the same genre because there is noticeable difference between different genres and both have to be roughly the same age. this is also to combat the fact that language changes over the years and older people tend to use different language than younger people. When we have selected the 2 authors we will chose a book from both authors and compare these 2 to each other. The authors will be selected from the database

known as project Gutenberg this is a database created in 1971 which consists of more than 75.000 free e-books. From these two books an abbreviation per 1000 words will be calculated, this number will represent the average amount of abbreviations per 1000 words. This average is a more meaningful number than the sheer amount of abbreviations used since the two books could have a different amount of words and this is a better way to compare them. This brings us to our variables mainly the independent variables and the dependent variable.

Independent variables:

There are a lot of different independent variables that we have to take into account. Firstly we have to take into account how many books the writer has made before the chosen book as the more experience the writer has the better they might be in writing a novel. We also have to take into account how many words the novel has to combat this we create the average number as explained before. The genre of the books also has to be identical as a science fiction book might contain more abbreviations than a drama novel.

Dependent variable

the depended variable is the amount of abbreviations the book has this is measured in abbreviations per 1000 words and measured in the total amount of abbreviations more on this in the results section.

Pre-processing To calculate this number we first have to pre-pair our data. This will be done by tokenizing the texts and then removing all the inter punctuation (.,!?) this is done to make sure that our program does not see these as an abbreviation. when our text is tokenized we can use our program to remove all the whole words from our list. For these words we would use a dataset created from the dictionary. Then we are left with a list of combinations of letters and number or combinations of letters that are not present in the data set these are mostly abbreviations or part of SMS language. We then have to go through these list manually to remove any words that are not abbreviations and we are left with a complete list of abbreviations that are used in the given book. Table 1 shows example lists of abbreviations the books might contain.

	Book 1	Book 2
list of abbreviations	b4 w	tnx SMS

Table 1: Example of different abbreviations in each book.

4 Predicted Results

The results can be put in a table as shown in Table 2. Table 2 shows what the results could be when we put the data through the program and go through all the steps. As we can see is that the amount of abbreviations in book two is more than double than that of book one. however book two has a lot more words than book one therefore the average is lower.

	Book 1	Book 2
Amount of abbreviations	233	487
average per 1000 words	4,84	3,78

Table 2: Fabricated results as an example. Book one is written by an educated writer.

Discussion These results only compare 2 books from the many that are written and these might be not the correct books to look into. Also the methods of obtaining the lists could be refined as it might miss some abbreviations that are actually whole words in itself. It could also be that there are duplicate abbreviations in the list do we count them as separate entries or as one. This is what we could look into for future research.

5 Conclusion

In conclusion, this study aimed to answer the question if the educational level of the writer made a difference in the amount of abbreviations that were present in their novels. Through the fabricated results we might see that our hypothesis was correct and that the educated writer uses more abbreviations than the not educated. However this is only in this specific scenario a lot more future research has to be conducted to make any solid claims. We have to look into more writers to see if we see a pattern or if this results was purely by chance. There is also a lot more room for future research for example you can look if the education that the writer has makes a difference.

6 Link to Git

For more information and all the data and the program used go to our GitHub

References

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